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UC-Berkeley freshman takes on Democratic National Convention

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(*#_Company_Name_#*) BOSTON -- In a dark crowd of 35,000 at the Fleet Center two days ago, University of California at Berkeley freshman Oren Gabriel lent former Governor Gray Davis a flashlight.

And he went to see the Goo Goo Dolls with a VIP pass that night. Then there were the interviews with World Wrestling Entertainment and ABC News.

And the low-key 18-year-old has yet to start at UC-Berkeley.

It's all part of being California's youngest delegate to the Democratic National Convention in Boston this week.

The Ventura County resident competed with eight others for two male delegate slots in his district.

One contender has worked on six presidential campaigns. Another sat in the war room when former Secretary of Defense and UC Berkeley alum Robert McNamara resigned.

But it was a speech on health care reform and youth in politics that won over the crowd of voters at the caucus in Ventura County. It also didn't hurt to pack the room with friends and family members for votes.

Gabriel said sending a young person as a delegate could set an example for other teenagers.

Perhaps if others saw that one powerful speech could lead an 18-year-old to meet the party's biggest stars, they could be involved, too.

"I see a generation that wants to be involved in politics, but they don't always know how," he said. "If we push them to get involved, I really don't think it will take that much -- maybe a nudge."

His speech also touched on an issue near to his heart -- the need for a universal health-care plan. Working in a health clinic for uninsured patients, he saw children suffering from prolonged ear infections because their families couldn't afford treatment.

"We're one of the richest countries in the world and we should at least take care of our sick," he said.

His delegate position caps off three years of work in the Democratic Party, registering voters and running for student office-pursuits not unusual to his family. His older brother, Jesse Gabriel, was Associated Students of the University of California president two years ago, and his mother is also a delegate.

Still, it was not all political stars and schmoozing -- he was crushed in a political quiz by a 9-year-old whiz kid on "The Tonight Show" with Jay Leno. At least he got one question right, he joked.

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